

Short Version Notes on Augustine's Human Nature:

1. Introduction: Augustine's Concern with Human Nature

Augustine's core inquiry into human nature arises from his wrestling with the **origin of sin** and how it could be **reconciled** with God's omnibenevolence and omnipotence. Observing a persistent **inclination to evil** in himself and society, he concluded that humanity's nature must have been **corrupted** at some primordial point—leading him to the **Genesis** story of Adam and Eve.

- **Key Claim:** There is a universal, innate **human nature** now biased toward sin, which requires God's grace for its healing and redemption.

2. The Fall and Original Sin

Augustine interprets the **Genesis** account of Adam and Eve's disobedience in the Garden of Eden (often called "the Fall") as the historical and theological foundation for **original sin**:

1. **The Garden:** Adam and Eve enjoyed harmonious relationships (with each other and with nature) and could fully control their bodily desires via **rational will** before the fall.
2. **The Fall Itself:** Their **disobedience** toward God (rooted in **pride** and self-love) incurred a punishment that marred not just them personally but **all humankind**. After they sinned, Adam and Eve were banished from Eden, laboring under pain and toil in a fallen world.
3. **Transmission of Corruption:** Through **generational inheritance**, every human is born with this corrupted nature (the "mass of damnation" or *massa damnata*). For Augustine, the mode of transmission involves **sexual concupiscence**—we inherit Adam's guilt through the manner in which we are conceived.

Argument in Premises and Conclusion Form

- **P1:** Humans across history display a persistent tendency toward wrongdoing (uncontrolled desire, disobedience).
- **P2:** A perfectly good God would not directly create a nature doomed to sin.
- **P3:** Therefore, sin must have originated in human choice (not in God) and then **spread** to all descendants.
- **C:** Humanity universally bears **original sin** from Adam's first transgression.

3. Concupiscence and Bodily Desire

Augustine uses the term **concupiscence** for the insubordinate desires that humans cannot fully control. While concupiscence broadly covers *any* sinful or excessive urge, sexual concupiscence becomes a particularly **vivid symbol** of fallen human nature:

- **Pre-Fall Condition:** Adam and Eve were capable of rationally regulating sexual activity purely for procreative and harmonious purposes, without overpowering lust.
- **Post-Fall:** Sexual desire “overpowers reason,” illustrating the soul’s general loss of mastery over the body and over itself. This bodily “disobedience” is a direct **penalty** for the first act of disobedience.

4. Seminal Transmission of Sin

Augustine supposes that all future generations were “in the loins of Adam,” so once his nature was corrupted, **every** human offspring shares that corrupt nature. While he acknowledges that his biological understanding of reproduction (involving “seminal presence”) was rudimentary, he persists in the theological principle:

- **All humans inherit Adam’s guilt** and disordered desires via procreation.
- Hence, each newborn is **morally tainted** from the start and desperately needs **baptism** and **grace**.

5. Grace, Predestination, and Limited Election

Because original sin “paralyzes” our natural freedom to do good, Augustine holds:

1. **Necessity of Grace:** We cannot fix our will on the good or maintain faith in Christ by our own powers; only God’s **gracious intervention** can heal our will.
2. **Predestination:** God elects some to receive grace, enabling them to *persevere* in faith. Those not chosen remain in their sin and damnation.
3. **Punishment and Mercy:** Since all are guilty, God could justly punish everyone. Instead, He graciously rescues some—**limited election**—but always on account of His hidden but righteous wisdom.

Short Premise–Conclusion

- **P1:** Original sin cripples human will, leaving us unable to love God fully on our own.
- **P2:** Only divine grace can restore the human will.
- **P3:** God’s benevolent choice to give grace is unmerited and given to some but not all.

- **C:** Therefore, salvation is a matter of **predestined grace**, and human responsibility is limited but real (since we willfully fell in Adam, and only a gracious act can free us).

6. Consequences for Ethics and Human Society

In sum, Augustine's teaching on **human nature** has wide ethical and social implications:

- **Inevitable Conflict:** Our "fallen" or corrupt nature inclines us to evil.
- **Divine Help:** Society can only be truly reformed by God's grace; no purely human political project or moral philosophy can *independently* remove the root of sin.
- **Children's Baptism:** Infants, though seemingly innocent, share in Adam's guilt; hence, Augustine defends infant baptism as urgently necessary.
- **Gender and Sexuality:** Augustine views woman as created to be man's helper in paradise and holds that sexual appetite is especially emblematic of postlapsarian disorder. Yet he insists both sexes share the same intellectual soul—hence are equally human, though under a hierarchy established pre-fall and exacerbated after.

Strengths of Augustine's Account of Human Nature

1. Profound Psychological Insight

Augustine's **introspective** approach—famed especially in the *Confessiones*—offers a searching analysis of how human beings inwardly battle between higher (rational, God-centered) and lower (selfish, lustful) loves. This psychological realism resonates with many who sense that willpower is genuinely hampered by **ingrained habits** and **contrary impulses**.

2. Consistent Theological Framework

Augustine ingeniously combines biblical narratives (Adam, the Fall) with **philosophical** tenets (Platonic hierarchy of being, Stoic "akrasia," etc.). The result is a **rich metaphysical system** that addresses both moral evil and divine goodness. His interpretive approach preserves both **God's omnipotence** (since God is not made responsible for evil) and **human agency** (original sin arises from human choice).

3. Explains the Universal Experience of Moral Struggle

By positing that **original sin** is transmitted to all, Augustine plausibly accounts for why moral failure and conflict is **so widespread**—no culture or individual escapes that inner disharmony. This universal diagnosis has struck many as powerfully explanatory.

Main Objections

1. Mill's Challenge: Human Freedom vs. Predestination

One objection, which can be likened to John Stuart Mill's later concerns, is that **predestination** violates a sense of **fairness** or human responsibility. If God foreordains some to salvation regardless of their own endeavors, how can individuals be held blameworthy—or even praised—for their actions? The theory appears to **erase** moral accountability. Augustine replies by insisting that Adam's sin was freely chosen and that our corrupted nature deserves punishment—yet critics argue this punishes humans for a sin they never personally committed.

2. Evolution and Scientific Critique

Modern genetics and evolutionary biology contradict the notion that all humanity descended from **just two individuals** (Adam and Eve). The story of a **historical** Eden falls afoul of scientific consensus on human origins. Likewise, Augustine's biologically naive explanation of how original sin is physically transmitted through sexual conception is hard to reconcile with genetics, prompting critics to label it pseudoscience.

3. Pelagius: Sinful Habits Are Socially Conditioned

Pelagius (and modern heirs) accuse Augustine of **fatalistically** attributing evil impulses to nature rather than to how we are raised or taught. They argue that **it only appears** we are innately depraved because we grow up in deeply flawed societies. This line of critique says Augustinian pessimism about human nature can discourage moral effort and activism. Pelagius further insists that God's many moral commands in Scripture imply humans have a **real capacity** to do good by free will.

4. Injustice of Punishing Inherited Sin

Philosophically, it seems unfair or illogical to hold newborns guilty for Adam's sin. Especially the idea that **innocent children** might suffer diseases (like cancer) as God's just punishment for original sin appears harsh or contradictory to God's **omnibenevolence**. Augustine's solution that "God's judgments are secret yet just" does not satisfy those who see it as a **moral contradiction**.

Final Note

Augustine's doctrine of **human nature**—encapsulating original sin, fallen will, and dependence on grace—has shaped Western theological and philosophical thought profoundly. It continues to spark debate for its **psychological acumen**, its **theological coherence**, and its potential **ethical and scientific** friction points.